

COURSE FILE

PC754: Introduction to Photography

Credit Structure: 1-0-4-3

Program: MDes (Communication Design)

Year: 1

Semester: 2

Duration: 13 Days (Full Day – Lecture + Studio)

Timing: 9 AM – 6 PM

Course Instructor: Anirban Dutta Gupta

Couse Placement: Core course for MDes (CD) Semester 2. This is a specialised course in design and is aimed at integrating inputs provided in previous courses in semester 1 and 2 into a 'multimedia' matrix and orient the students to its multimodal application.

Course Format: Module based. The course is taught as a combination of Lectures and Studio sessions. Lectures introduce concepts, which are then analysed and explored via studio sessions and assignments. Lecture and studio is integrated and in certain cases can overlap. Teaching is through hand-on learning and through learning-by-doing and via real-time demonstrations and guidance by faculty members. Students will be expected to conduct fieldwork.

Course Objective and Content:

The Photography course will aim to provide a holistic understanding of photography as a subject of historical study, a medium of capturing the world and as a communication tool. A variety of photographic approaches, both current and historical, will be explored to allow you to understand the medium in its multiple representative forms.

The course will introduce 'why' and the 'how' of photography – with 'why' covering the creative and communication aspect of photography, while the 'how' will define the technical aspect of achieving it.

The technical and creative development of photography through time will broadly cover the mechanics of generating an image and the function of the camera using the DSLR as the representative device. The focus will be on the digital medium of photography against the more traditional chemical medium, and its subsequent image manipulation using software's like Photoshop.

Course Abstract:

Photography, in simple terms, is the method of recording images by the action of light or similar related radiation on a material or device specially designed to be sensitive to it. The term 'Photography' comes from the word *Photos=Light* and *graphein=to draw* and was coined by John F W Herschel in 1839. By that count, the world of photography is little more than 180 years old. In the past century and half - technology, science and art of photography has expanded dramatically. However, the concept of photography is even older than this. In 1000 AD Ibn Al-Haytham invented the pinhole camera - the *Camera Obscura*. Interestingly the law of optics was observed even earlier by Aristotle in 330 BC. Therefore, one can safely say that it is more than 2 millennia of quest that has led us into today's world of photography.

The first 'photograph' was taken in 1827 by Joseph Niepce. This is a defining moment as before this the *Camera Obscura* was for observation and drawing, for example, by the renaissance painters who used it for accurate reference of perspective. Niepce was the first one to actually record the event on an engraving plate coated in bitumen. This was the beginning of experimentation on chemical photosensitive agents eventually leading to the photographic camera and film.

From its beginning as a method of observation till today - photography is seen as a medium of expression as well as a science of documentation. Fields of photography extends from photography as an art form, photography as a product, photography as documentation, photography as evidence, photography as science and photography as experiment.

This module on **‘Introduction to Photography’** will explore certain key aspects of photography and build on previously learnt skillsets to relook framing an image using the camera - through observation, content, context, composition, colour, and light - primarily to understand and build an aesthetic sensibility. The students will learn to train the eye for a perfect composition through the viewfinder and learn to effectively capture expressive moments with accuracy and aesthetics to develop a sense of storytelling through still images.

In parallel, this module will also introduce the mechanics of taking a photograph. The digital camera, its various settings and its interplay, usage of light and image correction and manipulation, the role of the exposure triangle. The objective would be to not just provide aesthetic input but to also provide the technical inputs – concept of aperture, ISO, shutter speed, depth of field – so that what is imagined and seen can be effectively captured. The students will also be exposed to Adobe Photoshop for post-production processing of images.

At the end of the course the students will put up an exhibition of their selected work for the community to see.

Students will be given various assignments through which they will explore the concepts discussed in class.

Readings will be given to the students which they are expected to complete during the course. The learnings from this course will be continued and built upon in the Filmmaking module.

Knowledge and Skill targets:

Knowledge:

1. Understanding of film
2. Film language and grammar
3. Film semiotics
4. Constructing a narrative
5. Translation of thought into narrative to physical product
6. Understanding sound
7. Diegetic, Non-Diegetic, Trans-diegetic and Intra-Diegetic sound
8. Sound and emotion
9. Visualising and planning sound
10. Sound, Image, Text and culture
11. Impact of sound, image and text in communication design
12. Deploying as multimedia assets
13. Film as a communication product
14. Different film formats and its deployment
15. Lighting
16. Language of edit

Skill:

1. Scripting and narrative construction
2. Production planning
3. Camera use and understanding technical parameters and its results
4. Understanding light and its use
5. Editing- visual and sound
6. Recording and creating soundscape
7. Video editing software
8. Sound and image editing software

9. Multimedia integration software
10. Organising sound recording setup

Softwares:

1. Adobe Premiere Pro
2. Adobe Animate
3. Adobe Audition
4. Audacity

Hardware:

1. Camera
2. Lights
3. Edit systems
4. Sound recording equipments (zoom mic, microphones, boom rods)
5. Sound studio

Assessment Method: Continuous assessment of application of concepts through the duration of the course, along with assessment of group and individual assignments given. Assessment will not only cover the assignments, but professionalism, precision, pride, care and discipline displayed by the students.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8	P9	P10	P11	P12
	X	X	X	X		X	X	X	X	X	X

Course Outcome:

The course aims to equip the students with professional knowledge –creative, narrative and technical – involving the art and craft of field and studio photography. This course prepares

the students for professional application of photography as a communication and storytelling device and lays the groundwork for further specialized courses in this field.

Growth Matrix:

Flow	Objectives
1	Goal 1: Introduction to Photography Objective: To understand and appreciate the evolution of photography and its processes
2	Goal 2: Introduction to the camera Objective: Understanding the camera, the image making technologies, its manipulation, exposure triangle, composition
3	Goal 3: Introduction to Photographic Composition Objective: On photographic composition and meaning-making
4	Goal 4: Introduction to lighting and studio photography Objective: Appreciation of the impact of light on photography and using artificial light to construct mood and emotion
5	Goal 5: Documentary photography: Approaches, ethics and challenges Objective: On working in uncontrolled real environment
6	Goal 6: Introduction to photo-editing (tools, techniques and approaches) Objective: Understanding the image manipulation softwares
7	Goal 7: Editorial practices Objective: Structuring photographs to tell stories

Some things to keep in mind:

- Attendance is mandatory. You will have to be present during class hours.
- All assignments have to be completed.
- Use of any form of AI tools to generate concepts is strictly forbidden unless discussed in class and allowed for the specific assignment.

Reference:**1. The Burden of Representation** *by John Tagg*

770.1.TAG.024632

- Chapter 1: Democracy of the Image (Pg. 34 – 59)
- Chapter 2: Evidence, Truth & Order (Pg.60 – 65)
- Chapter 6: The currency of the photograph (Pg.153 – 183)
- Chapter 7: Contacts/Worksheet (Pg.184 – 211)

2. The Fundamentals of Photography *by Helen Drew*

770.DRE.024422

- Section 5: Genre (Pg.63 – 107)

3. The Photographic Reader *by Liz Wells*

770.WEL.024505

- Reflections on Photography: Introduction (Pg.12 – 18)
- Extracts from Camera Lucida (Pg 19 – 30)
- Extracts from 'The work of art in the age of mechanical reproduction (Pg.42 – 52)
- Fire & Ice (Pg.76 – 80)
- Photographic Seeing: Introduction (Pg.81 - 89)

- Introduction to the Photographers Eye (Pg.97 – 103)
- Rhetoric of the Image (Pg.114 – 125)
- A Photograph (Pg.126 – 129)
- Looking at Photographs (Pg.130 – 137)
- Photodigital: Introduction (Pg.198 – 201)
- The Shadow of the Object (Pg.202 – 217)
- Introduction to the photographic image in digital culture (Pg. 218 – 227)
- The Paradoxes of Digital Photography (Pg.240 – 249)
- Documentary & Photojournalism: Introduction (Pg.252 - 256)
- In, around and afterthought (Pg.261 – 274)
- The Photographic Gaze (Pg.324 – 326)
- Double Take (Pg.343- 353)
- The Photograph as an intersection of gazes (Pg.354 – 374)